

Gmail and Google Talk

10.1 Introduction

Gmail truly stands out when compared to other popular e-mail providers such as Yahoo!, Hotmail, and Rediff. At a time when e-mail box sizes hadn't touched 100 MB, Gmail offered an incredible 1 GB, and later increased it to 2 GB. Gmail was the first to allow files up to 10 MB as attachments, when the other providers offered a tenth of that. Gmail was also the first to incorporate an instant messaging system within the e-mail service.

In addition, Gmail brought in the concept of Labels, as distinct from the concept of Folders. Labelling allows greater categorisa-

Gmail And Targeted Ads

Google's lifeline is ads. To enhance the chances that visitors to a site will click on the ads, Google has to ensure that the ads are in some way related to the content on the site. So, for example, a Web page on airplanes will have ads from travel agencies, aeronautical engineering firms, flight schools, etc, rather than from marriage bureaus or fast food chains. To be able to deliver relevant ads, Google browses through the page, identifies words that appear frequently, and puts up ads from advertisers who have paid for their ads to appear in those pages that contain those words. So in the earlier example, flight schools will pay to have their ads appear on pages where "Airplane" is mentioned. This is Targeted Advertising. Needless to say, the greater the information collected from the Web page, the better the targeting.

While browsing through a Web page to identify words is harmless, doing this to private e-mails raises heckles—Google uses targeted advertising in Gmail. So if you receive an e-mail that has mention of the word "vacation", you're bound to see ads that suggest getaways.

People have concerns about someone else wading through their mailbox which they themselves access with a password. It raises privacy and legal issues. These concerns were allayed by Google after it was clarified that the process is entirely automated, and that no human being reads the e-mails! Advertisers, too, are not privy to e-mail content and the personal details of the e-mail user. Every user accedes to these conditions while signing up for Gmail (remember the terms of service you didn't bother to read?).